

Designing Ethically

What measures must be taken to ensure the physical and mental well-being of the user during UX design?

An analysis of relevant publications highlights two critical concepts that must be considered during the design process: 'ethical design' and 'dark patterns'

Fundamentally, ethical design entails making deliberate design choices that promote well-being and prevent harm, whether intentional or inadvertent. For instance, a common tactic of user interface interference involves aesthetic manipulation to obscure or conceal relevant information from the user. Consequently, the primary considerations in UX design must be usability—creating intuitive interfaces—and ensuring user efficiency and satisfaction in achieving specific objectives.

As the digital landscape expands, privacy has emerged as a paramount concern that must be addressed during the design phase. Presently, our "personal" information is arguably no longer entirely personal, given the extensive access large corporations and organizations have to private data. In the current era of Artificial Intelligence, where data serves as a crucial resource, privacy necessitates the protection of users' personal and sensitive information against potential misuse and breaches. Therefore, when designing systems, the collection and utilization of personal data must be minimized; privacy is no longer merely an ethical imperative for user safety, but a legal obligation.

Furthermore, the concept of dark patterns has evolved—primarily within design practice—yet it strongly resonates with persuasion strategies. While designers often need to influence user behavior and cognitive processes, employing persuasion tactics that manipulate a user's perspective to coerce them into purchasing a specific subscription solely for profit maximization is highly unethical.

Ultimately, during the design process, we must remain acutely aware of the impact our products have on mental health, ensuring our work aligns intrinsically with human needs.

References

- [1] J. Ghanchi, "Ethical Design: Why Is It Critical for UX Designers?," *UXmatters*, Feb. 2021. [Online]. Available: <https://www.uxmatters.com/mt/archives/2021/02/ethical-design-why-is-it-critical-for-ux-designers.php>. [Accessed: Mar. 22, 2026].
- [2] M. Fansher, S. S. Chivukula, and C. M. Gray, "#darkpatterns: UX Practitioner Conversations About Ethical Design," in *Extended Abstracts of the 2018 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '18)*, Montreal, QC, Canada, 2018, Art. no. LBW082. doi: 10.1145/3170427.3188553.